This dreary, cold and isolated region had a single track running through it, linking Qizil Jilga in the north to Samzungling in the south, which was made into a motorable road by the Chinese. In April 1962, Major Randhawa along with Captain D. S. R. Sawhney, Lieutenant Chhewang Rigzen, fifteen militiamen and seventeen porters with forty yaks and ponies had started from Sultan Chushku to establish forward posts in the vicinity of Sumdo. The route was dotted with glaciers; blizzards made the going extremely difficult, but Randhawa persevered, eventually setting up three pickets. The main post was code-named Jyotish, and a DZ was established there so it could be supplied by air. A second picket was a staging camp while the third, at 17,700 feet, was an OP from where all Chinese posts in the Sumdo region were clearly visible. By the time the party returned to DBO, twenty-nine of the forty animals had died of cold and exhaustion.

Lieutenants Rahim and Surat Singh, Captain Chatterji (the medical officer), three JCOs and forty-four militiamen were manning the three pickets when the Chinese opened fire with mortars on the night of 19 October 1962. Though Jyotish was the larger camp, all three officers were at the higher observation camp when the bombardment started. Owing to the difficulty faced by the Sinkiang troops in ferrying ammunition to those heights, the firing was sporadic and there was no question of the Chinese putting in an infantry attack. However, it was also obvious that the Indians could not hold out indefinitely, especially if the DZ was under fire. At 3 p.m., Rahim received Das's orders to withdraw. The Indians moved out at nightfall, and made it to Sultan Chushku after six days, exhausted and in need of medical aid. Fortunately, there were no casualties in the Qara Qash Sector, which by itself was a tribute to the staying ability of the militiamen.

Technically, the Galwan River Valley was a part of the Middle Sector, but geographically not only was it contiguous with the Qara Qash region, it was also equally forbidding and harsh. The Galwan theatre of operations extended over eighty kilometres in length with an average breadth of twenty-four kilometres. The highest peak in the area was 22,220 feet and the Galwan River's source itself was at 19,000 feet, dropping down sharply through the Galwan Basin to the Shyok River junction at 14,700 feet. Fast-flowing tributaries of the Galwan had cut deep gorges across the landscape, which were devoid of even animal tracks. The major characteristic of the Galwan Valley was that the river cut through the main Karakoram Range, which sloped towards the left bank of the Shyok River for almost forty-